

The Singing Spring

Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

For as long as anyone could remember, the Singing Spring had sung high in the hills, and its song had kept every well in the Olive Town cool and brimming. Then, one grey morning, the song simply stopped. The wells sank low. The olive leaves hung limp and thirsty, and the whole valley felt as if it were holding its breath.

Old Daphne, keeper of the olive grove, called the two of you to her side. "You have clever heads and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more up there than any sword. Will you climb the hill and wake the spring?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: a ball of golden thread, a honey cake wrapped in a leaf, and a small lyre worn smooth with playing. "Remember," she said, "in these hills we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being clever, brave, and kind."

What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Wits, Courage, or Heart?

Stop 1: The Riddle Gate

The road climbed into the sun, and at the top stood a tall gate of white marble. On its warm steps lay a sphinx, her body a lion's, her wings folded gold, her face calm and clever. She watched you with the patience of someone who has all the time in the world.

"None may pass," she said, "until they answer my riddle." There was no cruelty in it. If anything, she looked pleased to have visitors who might actually think.

Will you listen closely and puzzle it out together? A brave, thoughtful guess is welcome too. What do you try?

When your answer came, the sphinx dipped her great wings and drew the gate aside. "Well thought," she said, almost smiling, and let you through.

Stop 2: The Winding Maze

Beyond the gate the path split, and split again, into a maze of old stone walls where every turning looked exactly like the last. One wrong choice and you might wander until dark.

A goat-legged satyr swung up onto a wall, grinning. It was Bramble, who loved a traveller and a good joke in equal measure. He hummed a tune and tipped his head down one shadowed lane.

How will you keep from losing your way? You carry a ball of golden thread, and Bramble seems willing to help. What is your plan?

By tying the thread at the entrance and letting it trail behind you, every step became a step you could undo. The maze could not trap a hero with a thread, and soon you stepped out into the long golden light of evening.

Stop 3: The Lonely Giant

And there, at last, was the spring. But a giant sat squarely in front of it: one enormous eye, two folded arms, and a face set hard as the cliff behind him. Your heart thumped. He looked, for a moment, like the end of the adventure.

Then he sniffed. And you understood. He was not angry. He was lonely. No traveller had ever stayed to speak with him, and the long silence had made him gruff.

This was never a fight. What kindness could you show him? You have a honey cake to share. You could ask his name, or simply tell him that he is not alone. What do you do?

When you offered your kindness, the giant's huge eye brimmed over, and he wiped it with the back of one enormous hand. "You stayed," he whispered, as though he could hardly believe it. "You are my friends." And he shuffled, very gently, aside.

The Spring Sings Again

You stood at the edge of the quiet water and lifted the little lyre. The tune you played was simple and a touch wobbly, but it came straight from the heart, and that was all the spring had been waiting for.

The surface trembled. Up through the spray rose the Singing Nymphs, laughing, their voices weaving into a song so bright it seemed to lift the whole hillside. The spring leapt back to life, and far below, every well in the Olive Town brimmed cool and clear once more.

High on cloud-wrapped Olympus, wise Athena looked down and smiled. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your wits, with your courage, and above all with your kindness. Well done, heroes of the Sunlit Hills.

The Singing Spring: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means three small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, and the children's biggest fan. This is a cooperative game for two players who play together. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a braver tale than some, but cleverness and kindness still win every time, and no one is ever truly hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Olive Town.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Wits** (clever thinking), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Heart** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a ball of string for the golden thread, a small cake or token for the honey cake, and anything at all for a lyre. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join their two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Wits and Heart together, say, or Courage and Wits).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help the other instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed.

Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. In these hills, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	A friendly satyr gives you one free hint.

2	You find your courage again, and take back one energy star.
3	A favourable wind, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	Chiron the centaur passes by and nods kindly. All is well.
5	An olive branch for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A burst of birdsong, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

The Lonely Cyclops at the spring is the "foe", but he is no villain. He is a giant who has been alone too long. The tale is won not by beating him but by befriending him, and then by waking the Singing Nymphs with a tune. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Singing Spring: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward cleverness and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Riddle Gate (Normal)

The challenge. The Riddle Sphinx will not open the gate until the players answer her riddle. She is fair and patient, and she enjoys a good thinking face.

The riddle. Read it aloud: *"I have roots that nobody sees. I am taller than the tallest trees. Up, up, up I go, and yet I never grow. What am I?"* The answer is **a mountain** (think of Olympus rising above you).

Intended solution. This is a thinking challenge of Wits and a little Vocabulary. Let the children talk it through together. The sphinx accepts the right answer, and because she is kind, she also accepts a brave, thoughtful guess.

Fallback. If they are stuck, the sphinx offers a clue ("You can see me from your town, and the gods live on my head"), or Bramble the satyr whispers the answer from behind a rock. A guess made bravely still opens the gate.

Stop 2: The Winding Maze (Normal)

The challenge. Beyond the gate is a maze of stone walls where every path looks the same. The players must find their way through without getting lost.

Intended solution. This is a Spatial and Logic moment. The clever move is to use the **golden thread**: tie one end at the entrance and unspool it as you go, so you can always retrace your steps and never walk the same wrong path twice. Marking each turn, or asking **Bramble the Satyr** for a hint, works just as well.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have Bramble pop up and point the way with a joke, or let them spend an energy star to "remember" the route. Getting through with help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Lonely Cyclops (Hard, then no roll)

The challenge. A huge one-eyed giant sits in front of the spring with his arms folded. He looks fearsome, and the players may feel this is a fight. It is not.

Intended solution. This is a Heart and Courage moment. The giant is simply lonely; nobody ever visits him. Any genuine kindness works: sharing the **honey cake**, asking his name, telling him he is not alone, inviting him to be a friend. When the children are kind, he moves aside with happy tears. Then they wake the spring by playing the **little lyre**, and the **Singing Nymphs** rise and sing.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or want to "win" by force, have the giant sniffle and ask, very quietly, "Are you scared of me too?" A single kind word melts him. The moment the players try any tune at all, the nymphs wake and the water sings.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the spring sings, every well in the Olive Town fills again, the giant has friends at last, and wise **Athena** smiles down from the mountain. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being clever, brave, and kind.

The Singing Spring: Idea Bank

Improv fuel for when a child goes happily off-script. Pull from these freely; none of it can break the story. Everything here is brave and kind, in keeping with these hills, where heroes win by wits, courage, and heart, never by force.

The three hero qualities

Wits: spotting a clue others miss, asking the one good question, solving a riddle, reading the lay of the land, a clever plan, turning a problem upside down, remembering an old story that helps.

Courage: taking the first step on a dark path, speaking gently to something fearsome, owning up to a mistake, trying again after a miss, standing in front of a friend, keeping a steady voice when your knees shake.

Heart: sharing food, asking a stranger's name, offering friendship, comforting a sad creature, keeping a promise, cheering up a companion, choosing the kind way over the easy way.

Helpful friends along the way

- **Bramble the Satyr** pops up with jokes and hints whenever the heroes are stuck.
- **Chiron the Centaur**, wisest of teachers, might trot by to offer a calm word.
- The **Singing Nymphs** of the spring reward kindness with a song.
- The **Riddle Sphinx** is stern at her gate but warm once you have answered.
- Even the **Lonely Cyclops** becomes a gentle friend who carries the heroes on his shoulders for fun.

Handy things to find or build

- The **golden thread** for any maze or dark place.
- The **honey cake**, and other small gifts: a ripe fig, a flower crown, a smooth river stone, a token of friendship.
- The **little lyre**, a set of pan-pipes, a bright song, a brave shout that echoes.
- An olive branch for peace, a water skin, a sun hat, a map drawn in the dust, a lucky knucklebone.

Places to wander

A sunlit olive grove, a marble temple full of echoes, a cool cave behind a waterfall, a meadow of poppies, a harbour of little fishing boats, a hilltop where you can see the whole sea.

Mini-challenges

Cross stepping stones in the right order, match a god to their symbol, calm a nervous goat, finish a half-remembered song, share out fruit so everyone gets a fair piece, find the one path that catches the morning sun.

Happy rewards

A laurel crown, a ride on the cyclops's shoulders, a new riddle to take home, a song the nymphs teach you, a basket of figs, or a wink from a goddess. Every reward is something to feel proud of; nothing is ever taken away.

Who's Who and What's What

Places

Mount Olympus - The cloud-wrapped mountain where the gods live, watching over the sunlit hills from far above.

The Olive Town - A little white town of terracotta roofs and olive trees, the heroes' home, where the spring has fallen quiet.

The Riddle Gate - A marble gate on the hill road, guarded by a sphinx who lets pass only those who answer a riddle with a cool head.

The Singing Spring - The spring of the nymphs high in the hills, whose song once filled every well in the valley. It has gone silent.

The Winding Maze - A maze of old stone walls and hedges where it is easy to get lost without a thread to follow.

Characters

Athena - The goddess of wisdom and good ideas, who smiles on heroes that win by thinking and caring rather than by force.

Daphne the Olive-Keeper - The kind old keeper of the town's olive grove, who knows every story of the hills and sends the heroes to wake the spring.

Creatures

Bramble the Satyr - A cheerful, goat-legged satyr of the woods who loves jokes and hands out helpful hints to travellers he likes.

Chiron the Centaur - The wisest and kindest of the centaurs, half horse and half person, a teacher of heroes who believes the best deeds are gentle ones.

The Lonely Cyclops - A huge one-eyed giant who guards the spring. He looks fearsome, but he is really just lonely, and a kind word and a shared honey cake do more than any sword.

The Riddle Sphinx - A great winged sphinx with a lion's body and a kind, clever face, who guards the gate and asks riddles. She is fair, not cruel, and a good answer or a brave guess opens the way.

The Singing Nymphs - Gentle spirits of the spring whose singing makes the water flow. When they are happy, every well in the valley fills again.

Items

The Golden Thread - A ball of shining thread. Tie one end at the entrance and you can always find your way back out of the maze.

The Honey Cake - A small sweet cake. Shared with a lonely guardian, it can turn a scowl into a smile.

The Little Lyre - A small harp. A simple tune played from the heart can wake the song of the spring.

Words to Know

Courage - A steady heart in a scary moment. Courage is not being unafraid; it is being kind and clever even when you are afraid.

Heart - Care for others. In this world the greatest heroes are the ones who help, share, and stand by a friend.

Wits - Quick thinking and good questions. In these hills, wits open more doors than strength.

My Adventure Sheet

My name _____

My magic (write or draw it)

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



Draw your hero

[illegible]

What I am carrying

Notes

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.